Nevertheless, I was confident that I had calculated the timing right, so I took the turn.

‘I can’t spot the helipad, can you?’ the captain asked.

I desperately scanned the area below to see if I could spot it. As per the stopwatch, only thirty seconds were left to reach the destination and if we didn’t spot the helipad, we would have to turn around and go back.

‘There it is!’ I exclaimed joyfully as smoke from the smoke candles became visible. Smoke candles were lit by the army near the helipad to help us spot it. I finally relaxed. My captain relaxed too. A sense of achievement pumped inside me.

Smoke swirled under the powerful rotors of our helicopter and waves of dust swept across the helipad as we descended. As soon as we landed and signalled the team there, stretcher bearers ran towards the helicopter with the casualty. The rotors were kept engaged, since time was of the essence. We took off as soon as the stretcher bearers got to a safe distance away from us. A major-ranked officer in charge of that unit smiled at us and gave us a thumbs up as he stood at the edge of the helipad clad in his worn-out dungarees. I smiled back, and flew away from the valley.

The mission had been a success and I couldn’t wait to see the look on my flight commander’s face. I hadn’t let him down. I was happy that even with less than three years of service, I had been considered for such a difficult sortie and I had pulled it off.

With India slowly emerging victorious in this war, a sulking Pakistan Army was trying to cause maximum damage to the Indian side, and its ill intentions led to an incident that shook me to such an extent that I was left scared for the first time since the war had begun.